I Hate Hamlet

By Paul Rudnick

The Characters: *Andrew (30's) a popular television actor, and Barrymore (40-50) a ghost.*
The Setting: *Present. A brownstone apartment in New York*
The Scene: *When Andrew is offered the role of Hamlet in a New York production, his subsequent anxiety summons the ghost of John Barrymore. Here, these two very different actors discuss method and romance.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: Andrew Rally, a young and successful television actor, relocates to New York when his series is cancelled. There he rents a marvelous, gothic apartment and is offered the opportunity to play Hamlet onstage in Central Park. Sounds like an actor's dream, right?

ACTOR 2: Well, it would be if Andrew Rally didn't hate Hamlet. His dilemma deepens with the entrance of John Barrymore's ghost, who arrives intoxicated and in full Shakespearean regalia.

TOGETHER: I Hate Hamlet by Paul Rudnick

ANDREW: You're... him.

BARRYMORE: AM I?

ANDREW: You're... dead.

BARRYMORE: You know, occasionally I'm not truly certain. Am I dead? Or just incredibly drunk?

ANDREW: You're... Barrymore.

BARRYMORE: Yes. Although my father's given name was Blythe; he changed it when he became an actor, to avoid embarrassing his family. Your name?

ANDREW: *(Still completely unnerved.)* Andrew. Rally. It's really Rallenberg. I changed it, to avoid embarrassing ... the Jews.

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BARRYMORE: *(Surveying the premises.)* Behold. My nest. My roost. *(Indicating where things had been, perhaps with musical cues.)* A grand piano. A renaissance globe. A throne.

ANDREW: You're dead! You're dead! What are you doing here?

BARRYMORE: Lad - I'm here to help.

ANDREW: Wait - how do I know you're ghost? Maybe you're just ... an intruder.

BARRYMORE: *(Toying with him.)* Perhaps. Cleverly disguised as Hamlet. *(Andrew slowly sneaks up on Barrymore. He touches Barrymore's forearm. Barrymore is very nonchalant.)* Boo.

ANDREW: But - I can touch you. My hand doesn't go through.

BARRYMORE: I'm a ghost, Andrew. Not a special effect.

ANDREW: But... ghosts are supposed to have powers! Special powers!

BARRYMORE: I just rose from the dead, Andrew. And how was your morning? Now shall I truly frighten you?

ANDREW: *(Not impressed)* I'm not afraid of you.

BARRYMORE: Shall I cause your flesh to quake?

ANDREW: *(Very cocky)* You couldn't possibly.

BARRYMORE: Shall I scare you beyond all human imagination?

ANDREW: Go ahead and try.

BARRYMORE: In just six weeks time, you will play Hamlet.

ANDREW: *(Screams, Genuinely terrified.)* Oh my God, you really are him, aren't you?

BARRYMORE: John Barrymore. Actor. Legend. Seducer. Corpse.

ANDREW: So- it worked. The séance. Felicia, her mother she brought you back, from over there.

BARRYMORE: Not at all. You summoned me.

ANDREW: I did?

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BARRYMORE: As a link in a proud theatrical tradition. Every soul embarking upon Hamlet is permitted to summon an earlier layer. From Burbage to Kean to Irving - the call has been answered.

ANDREW: Wait - you mean you're here to help me play Hamlet? Because you did it?

BARRYMORE: Indeed.

ANDREW: Okay. Fine. Then the problem's solved. Because I'm not going to play Hamlet. No way. So you can just ... go back. To... wherever.

BARRYMORE: I'm afraid that's not possible.

ANDREW: Why not?

BARRYMORE: I cannot return, I will not be accepted, until my task is accomplished. Until you have...

ANDREW and

BARRYMORE: Played Hamlet.

BARRYMORE: Precisely.

ANDREW: *(Completely floored)* Oh no. Oh my God. You mean, if I don't go through with it.

BARRYMORE: Then I'm here to stay. Within these walls. Trapped for all time, with a television actor.

ANDREW: Well, excuse me - I happen to be a very good television actor! And I don't need any dead ham bone to teach me about anything! Even if I were going to play Hamlet, which I'm not, I could do just fine! All by myself!

(Barrymore glares at Andrew. He removes a small, leather-bound copy of Hamlet from a pouch on' his belt, and tosses it to Andrew.)

BARRYMORE: Very well then: Hamlet. "To be or not to be."

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ANDREW: That happens to be the speech I did at my auditions. And I got the part. *(Andrew tosses the copy of Hamlet back to Barrymore)*

BARRYMORE: Proceed. *(Barrymore reclines full length on the couch. Andrew, very full of himself, decides to show Barrymore a thing or two. He strides in, and turns his back. He hunches over.)* Yes?

ANDREW: I'm doing my preparation.

BARRYMORE: Your... preparation.

ANDREW: Yes. My acting teacher taught me this. Harold Gaffney.

BARRYMORE: Harold Gaffney?

ANDREW: The creator of the Gaffney technique. Act To Win. I can't just do the speech cold, I have to get into character. I have to become Hamlet. I'm doing a substitution.

BARRYMORE: A substitution?

ANDREW: I'm thinking about something that really happened to me, so I can remember the emotion, and recreate it.

BARRYMORE: And what are you remembering?

ANDREW: It's a secret. Otherwise it won't work. Be quiet, I'm going to act.

BARRYMORE: Why do I feel we should spread newspapers about? I'm sorry, I shall be silent. Out of deep respect. Road closes - man acting. *(Andrew turns, and moves D. facing out. He makes a small snuffling noise. He loosens up his shoulders, like a prizefighter shadow-boxing. He makes a few faces; he is being ultra-naturalistic, very Method. He makes an ungodly howling noise, then slaps his own face. He repeats this. Barrymore watches all this, appalled.)* You know, Andrew, I am dead, and I shall be for all eternity. But I still don't have all day. *(Andrew begins again. After a few lunges, he begins to speak. His forehead is furrowed with intensity; his speech patterns are reminiscent of a Brooklyn tough guy, in the Brando / DeNiro mode.)*

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ANDREW: To be ... nah. *(He paces. A thought occurs.)* Or ... not ... to ... be. That, that is the question. Whoa. Whether... *(He holds up a hand.)* Whether 'tis nobler ... huh ... in the mind, right ...

BARRYMORE: Wrong.

ANDREW: What?

BARRYMORE: No.

ANDREW: What "No?"

BARRYMORE: No.

ANDREW: No, what? No you disagree with my interpretation, no my interpretation wasn't clear, no you think I'm totally horrible?

BARRYMORE: Yes.

ANDREW: I'm horrible?

BARRYMORE: At the moment. What were you doing?

ANDREW: I was internalizing the role. I was finding an emotional through -line.

BARRYMORE: Why?

ANDREW: Why? So the character will come alive! So I'll achieve some sort of truth! *(Barrymore rises, aghast.)*

BARRYMORE: Truth! Your performance - the pauses, the moans, all that you clearly consider invaluable - it's utterly appalling. We must never confuse truth with asthma.

ANDREW: What?

BARRYMORE: I understand the impulse, God help me, I lived just long enough for the introduction of truth into the modern theater. As I recall, it accompanied synthetic fibers and the GE Kitchen Of Tomorrow.

ANDREW: Oh - so you just want me to ham it up.

BARRYMORE: I beg your pardon?

ANDREW: Hamming. Mugging. Over the top. Too big. Too

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BARRYMORE: *(With a grand gesture)* Barrymore?

ANDREW: Well, you did have the reputation. As someone ... larger than life.

BARRYMORE: What size would you prefer? Gesture, passion these are an actor's tools. Abandon them, and the result? Mirror reality. Employ them, with gusto, and an artist's finesse, and the theater resounds! I do not overact. I simply possess the emotional resources of ten men. I am not a ham; I'm a crowd! Andrew, who is Hamlet?

ANDREW: A prince?

BARRYMORE: A star.

ANDREW: What?

BARRYMORE: A star. The role is a challenge, but far more an opportunity. To shine. To rule. To seduce. To wit - what makes a star?

ANDREW: Talent? *(They exchange a look.)* Sorry, I wasn't thinking.

BARRYMORE: A thrilling vocal range? Decades of training? The proper vehicle? *(He shakes his head, no.)* Tights.

ANDREW: Tights?

BARRYMORE: Tights. Where are you looking? Right now?

ANDREW: I am not!

BARRYMORE: Of course you are! The potato, the cucumber, the rolled sock - this is the history of Prince Hamlet.

ANDREW: You mean - you padded yourself?

BARRYMORE: Unnecessary. Even for the balcony. *(Pause, as he gazes upward.)* The second balcony.

ANDREW: So Hamlet should be ... horny?

BARRYMORE: Hamlet is a young man, a college boy, at his sexual peak. Hamlet is pure hormone. Ophelia enters, that most beguiling of maidens. Chastity is discussed.

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ANDREW: Please, don't joke. Not about chastity.

BARRYMORE: Why? What?

ANDREW: I can't talk about it.

BARRYMORE: Oh dear . Your beloved? A problem?

ANDREW: A nightmare. Five months.

BARRYMORE: What?

ANDREW: Nothing.

BARRYMORE: Truly?

ANDREW: Necking at the Cloisters. Picnics on Amish quilts. Sonnets.

BARRYMORE: Not... sonnets.

ANDREW: Yes. And I've been faithful. Totally. It's unnatural. Do you know what happens when you don't have sex?

BARRYMORE: No.

ANDREW: Thanks.

BARRYMORE: But why?

ANDREW: Why her, or why me? Deirdre won't have sex because ... she's not sure. Because she's the victim of a relentlessly happy childhood, which she fully expects to continue.

BARRYMORE: And you?

ANDREW: Me? Why do I put up with all this? Why have I begged Deirdre to marry me, practically since the day we met? Because, in the strangest way, she's the most passionate woman I've ever met. Because when she sees a homeless person, she gives them a fabric-covered date book. Deirdre's just ... she makes me think that love is as amazing as it's supposed to be. She's romantic, which means she's insane. I know I love her, because I want to strangle her. Does that make sense?

BARRYMORE: Of course, A virgin goddess.

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ANDREW: Please - don't encourage her.

BARRYMORE: She is to be treasured, and honored. I have known few such women in my sensual history. Perhaps only five hundred. They are the most adorable saints. But... there are ways.

ANDREW: *(Eagerly)* What?

BARRYMORE: No. It would be unthinkable.

ANDREW: What?

BARRYMORE: I could never condone such Casanova-like tactics. Such Valentino mesmerism.

ANDREW: Such Barrymore deceit.

BARRYMORE: *(Mortally offended)* Cad.

ANDREW: Yes?

BARRYMORE: Knave.

ANDREW: Please?

BARRYMORE: Hamlet!

ANDREW: No! Stop with that.

BARRYMORE: Hamlet, to cunningly expose his father's murder, feigns madness. To perfect the pose, he must spurn his beloved, the fair Ophelia. She is undone.

ANDREW: But doesn't she kill herself? I don't want to hurt Deirdre.

BARRYMORE: You'll be merciful.

ANDREW: No, that would be dishonest.

BARRYMORE: You would prefer, perhaps, some form of therapy? Continued discussion? What is the present-day epithet "communication?" That absolute assassin of romance?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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